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Commissioners support trail extension

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LISBON - Federal funding is being sought to extend the Little Beaver Creek Greenway Trail from Lisbon to East Liverpool.

Dottie Betz, president of the Columbiana County Park District board, met Wednesday with county commissioners to obtain a letter in support of efforts to obtain the money.

This is part of an effort by the Greater Ohio Lake-To-River Greenway Coalition to lobby area congressmen to secure enough federal funding to complete the proposed 115-mile bicycling/walking trail that would connect Ashtabula to East Liverpool by linking with existing trails.

Of the 115 miles, 64 miles have been completed, including the 10-mile Little Beaver Creek Greenway Trail that runs from Leetonia to Lisbon, with plans under way to get it extended north the final 1.5 miles to the Mahoning County line. Betz said they would like to extend it another 25 miles to the Point of Beginning in East Liverpool on the Pennsylvania line, following a patchwork of back roads and other means to get there.

Once completed, it would provide a link to other Greenway trails in the Pittsburgh area and beyond. The local Greenway trail is one of the most popular recreation stops in the county, drawing an estimated 100,000 users a year.

Betz said the proposal to extend the trail to the southern part of the county is garnering significant local support, especially from businesses who also would like to see a connector trail between East Liverpool and Wellsville.

Commissioners gladly signed off on the letter of support.

"I always refer to you as the Little Engine That Could," Commissioner Penny Traina said of the board, a reference to fact the park board accomplishes much with very little public funding. "You are small but mighty."

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